

The influence of social media on the consumers' hotel decision journey

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Abstract

Social media play a key role in tourism and hospitality, transforming the way tourists search, find and co-create information about travel-related products, and changing the way they make hotel-related decisions online. The use and influence of social media on consumers' hotel decision-making process however still remains vague to date. This study aimed to uncover how social media influence consumer behaviour during hotel decision-making through a qualitative semi-structured in-depth interview approach. The findings reveal refined dimensions of social media and their influence on the 'Evaluation stage' of the hotel decision journey. The findings revealed that the way consumers search hotel information have changes, as social media play an important role influencing their decision-making process. This study makes a theoretical contribution to understanding consumers' hotel decision-making process in a technology-assisted context, and offers implications for hospitality practitioners in highlighting how social media can lead to nuanced decision making in the hotel selection process.

1. Introduction

Prior to the 'age of social media', consumers traditionally had limited resources to collect information on services and products (Hu and Wei 2013), with accommodation purchases primarily informed by brochures and travel agents (Baruka and Civre 2012). In recent years, traditional sources of information have been replaced by social media (Fotis et al. 2012), as travellers started to consult user generated content (UGC) on social media to plan and make decisions on their hotel stay (Browning and Sparks 2013). In the context of tourism, consumers use social media for a wide spectrum of scenarios, e.g. sharing their travel-related experiences, engaging with others, connecting

with people from different destinations and buying travel-related products and services (Munar and Jacobsen, 2014; Zeng and Geritsen 2014). While the proliferation of information and communication technologies (ICTs) has always had a major effect on consumer behaviour in tourism, the Web 2.0 has transformed how tourists select and purchase tourism services online (Buhalis and Law 2008; Neuhofer et al. 2012; Gohil 2015). This is particularly true for the hotel sector. Hotel-related decision making has fundamentally changed (Hudson and Thal 2013), as social media are used in every stage of the consumers' Decision-Making Process (DMP). Prospective tourists are influenced through social media, as content from other travellers can shape, guide and redirect their initial decisions (Fotis et al. 2012).

However, the way 'how' and the reasons 'why' tourists use social media, and how social media influence the consumers' DMP, specifically in the hospitality context, still remains little understood (Cox et al. 2009; Ayeh et al. 2012; Gohil, 2015). Based on this premise, this research aimed to explore how social media influence consumer behaviour during the hotel DMP, contributing towards a better understanding of social media's role and influence on consumer behaviour in the tourism and hospitality domain. The study's core contribution advances the current body of literature by developing a social media facilitated consumers' hotel DMP model, which outlines nuances of the hotel search process, its advantages and disadvantages, the level of trustworthiness of social media in hotel information search and their influence on the overall hotel DMP. First, this study reviews social media in tourism and their use and influence on the travel DMP. Second, it presents the methodological approach of a qualitative in-depth query, followed by the results of the study, depicting the social media enabled hotel DMP. Finally conclusions are drawn, discussing the study's limitations and offering a range of theoretical and practical implications for the IT, tourism and hospitality domain.

2. Theoretical Background

2.1. The Proliferation of the Web 2.0 and Social Media

The Web 2.0 and social media have empowered companies and consumers to engage and participate in service-related processes more than ever before (Sigala et al. 2012). Social media are not new, however, their proliferation across various industries, and academic discussion of it has accelerated more recently (Fuchs 2014). For instance,

from a customers' point of view, social media have been a subject of investigation as to understand their role as information-sharing and searching platforms in facilitating consumers' autonomy (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010; Ayeh et al. 2012; Gohil, 2015) and creating value through the exchange and sharing of personal experiences through electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) (Litvin et al., 2008). In the business domain, social media received attention as electronic tools that transform the traditional marketing and advertising landscape (Sigala et al. 2012) and give practitioners a means for interaction, sharing of visual and audio content to have richer and more convenient conversations online (Community Futures 2012). Overall, social media have been portrayed as significant platforms for information exchange and interaction between businesses and consumers and among users, as well as wider mediators, controllers, and non-profit organisational stakeholders (Xiang and Gretzel 2010; Sigala et al. 2012).

A large number of social media applications exist today, with new networking sites and tools continuing to emerge online (Sigala et al. 2012; Munar and Jacobsen, 2014). To disentangle this complexity, several authors have mapped out dominant social media types. For instance, Constantinides and Fountain (2008) classify five main types, including blogs, social networks, content communities, forums and bulletin boards, and content aggregators. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) structure social media according to their a) level of social presence and media richness, and b) their level of self presentation and self disclosure, distinguishing six overall social media types. In the tourism domain, recent studies have advanced our knowledge by assessing the use of microblogs (e.g. Twitter), consumer reviews and rating websites (e.g. TripAdvisor) and Internet fora, some of which are particularly relevant for tourism related services (Xiang and Gretzel 2010; Ayeh et al. 2012; Fotis et al. 2012; Sigala et al. 2012; Hudson and Thal 2013; Chung and Koo 2015; Gohil 2015).

2.2. The Role of Social Media in Travel

Beyond their significant role in people's daily life and social contexts, social media have become an indispensable aspect of tourism (Zeng 2013; Yazdanifard and Yee 2014; Gohil 2015). 'Travel 2.0' captures the revolution of the travel industry towards a new generation of platforms and social interactions online, which has changed the way travellers search, rank, evaluate, purchase and consume products and services on the web (Buhalis and Law 2008; Hudson and Thal 2013). While a wide range of social

media come into play, the most frequently used social media for tourism and hospitality include TripAdvisor, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, MySpace and Flickr (McCarthy et al. 2010; Ayeh et al. 2012; Sigala et al. 2012). In synthesising recent travel-related social media work, it is clear that social media play a key role before, during and after the trip (Fotis et al. 2012). While several scholars agree that travellers use different social media for online information depending on each travel stage (Verma et al. 2012), it has been argued that social media unfold their most critical role in the pre-travel stage, when tourists consult social media for travel planning, information search and DMP (Cox et al. 2009; Zeng 2013).

In these crucial information search and decision stages, social media re-shape how consumers seek, detect, read, trust and exchange information online (Sigala et al. 2012). Travel-related UGC represents a key source for prospective travellers to understand previous travellers' experiences about destinations, facilities and restaurants (Litvin et al., 2008; Sigala et al. 2012). In fact, Cox et al. (2009) highlight that almost 80% of users who use social media for travel-related reasons are searching information regarding travel destinations and accommodation, with the majority of users consulting online hotel and travel reviews (Murphy and Chen 2014). In this process, social media are particularly used to support decision-making processes (Zeng 2013). Consumers trust material from other travellers on social media, while UGC is considered to be more trustworthy than any information provided by official tourism websites, travel agents and mass media advertising (Yo et al., 2009; Del Chiappa 2011; Fotis et al. 2012). While the benefits of social media have been widely noted, some controversy surrounds the power of UGC on social media, challenging its trustworthiness and authenticity of content (Cox et al. 2009; Fotis et al. 2012). This is important as Lopez and Sicilia (2014) claim that the perceived trustworthiness of a source determines the influence on consumer behaviour, and by extension, the influence on the consumer DMP.

2.3. Influence of Social Media on the Hotel Consumer Decision Journey

The DMP occurs in the pre-travel phase as part of the wider Consumer Decision Journey (CDJ) in which consumers undergo four stages: 1) Consider, 2) Evaluate, 3) Buy and 4) Enjoy, Advocate, Bond (Court et al. 2009). Court et al. (2009) reveal that instead of systematically limiting their choices until they have agreed on what to purchase, consumers add and subtract brands from a 'group of favourites' under

consideration in the '*Evaluation stage*'. In the evaluation stage, consumers start to search and process information from various sources to fulfill their purchasing needs and evaluate several alternatives based on their obtained information prior to the buying decision (Ayeh et al. 2012). This evaluation process shows however added difficulties in the selection of hotel and accommodation (Baruka and Civre 2012).

Due to their intangible nature, hotel products and services make the buying decision highly emotional and hard to replicate (Kwon et al. 2011). Hotel providers are no longer the unrivaled experts on the features or quality of brands and products. Instead, online reviews about hotels play a significant role in assisting contemporary consumers' evaluation stage, by providing positive and negative reviews and indirect customer-to-customer communication through blogs and review sites (Fotis et al. 2012; Hudson and Thal 2013). This is grounded in the principal foundations of consumer behavior, i.e. that consumers have the power to influence each other (Haywood 1989). While it is accepted that social media have the potential to influence travellers in the final purchase decision (Ayeh et al. 2012; Fotis et al. 2012), the specifics of how this process might unfold and behaviour is influent is less explored.

While social media are primarily used to assist consumers for inspirations, limiting choices and verifying decisions (Gretzel and Yoo 2008), hotel reviews are used to form a 'consideration set' of possible choices (Singh and Torres 2015). In this evaluation process, hotel decisions are frequently influenced by negative and positive customer reviews, as both ends of the spectrum increase customers' awareness and can change their attitudes towards a hotel (Vermeulen and Seegers, 2009). For instance, Verma et al. (2012) found that when a hotel has negative comments, it is less likely for prospective travellers to book the hotel, while Almana and Mirza (2013) demonstrate that higher ratings of reviews are effective factors in making purchasing decisions.

While the central role of social media in the DMP has been confirmed in recent studies, there is still a limited understanding of the detailed nuances that shape the CDJ, specifically the '*Evaluation Stage*'. Cox et al. (2009) argue that the role of UGC in the traveller's behaviour and DMP is one of the most unclear and under-researched topics. While a large body of research (e.g. Gretzel et al., 2007, Gretzel and Yoo 2008, Vermeulen and Seegers 2009, Murphy and Chen 2014) has examined the influence of

online reviews or specific platforms (e.g. TripAdvisor) on decision making, there is still a dearth of studies that take wider social media platforms on the CDJ into account. This study thus advocates the need a more nuanced understanding of how various types of social media influence the CDJ, and how they shape the final hotel decision-making (Constantinides and Fountain 2008). While previous work has developed frameworks around the CDJ, models that capture the hotel customer decision journey through social media, by considering the particularities of the hospitality context, are missing. Grounded in this rationale, this study aims to explore the hotel DMP through a qualitative in-depth approach to advance hospitality consumer behaviour and develop a useful model on the hotel consumer decision-journey through social media.

3. Methodology

A qualitative in-depth approach has been adopted to assess how consumers make their hotel choice decisions and to what extent they are influenced by social media in the 'Evaluation stage' process. A total of twelve individual face-to-face semi-structured in-depth interviews were conducted with social media users between the ages of 19 and 33 in the second-half of 2015 in the UK. A detailed interview instrument was developed based on the prior literature review to aid the discussion and help uncover underlying influences of social media use on individual hotel choices. In order to identify, recruit and select prospective interviewees based on a set of sampling criteria, a non-random, purposive sampling approach was employed. To qualify for participation in the study, participants were required to meet four criteria, including a) need to have travelled during the last two years, b) have stayed in a hotel during their trip, c) be active users of social media, defined as usage at least one hour per day and d) have used social media for travel related decision-making purposes.

Table 2 provides an overview of the socio-demographic profile and social media use of participants. While the age range is not representative of the entire population, it can be considered representative of the younger population of technology-savvy social media users, as identified by Pew Internet that more than eight in ten Internet users (aged 18-29) use social networking sites, compared to seven users (aged 30-49) and half or less than half of the users (50-64 and beyond), suggesting a relationship between higher age and decreasing ICTs use (Lennon et al. 2012). The sample profile reflects these age groups with the majority of participants in the age groups 18-21 (16,6%), 22-25

(41,6%), 26-29 (33,4%) and 30-33 (8,4%). The results of this study can be considered transferable to a wider population of technology-savvy users, who use social media in their daily life and their hotel information search. The social media statistics offer an insight into the usage hours per day and most frequently used social media platforms for hotel related decision-making. For the qualitative data analysis, Miles and Huberman's (1994) approach of thematic analysis was adopted, consisting of a multiple coding process, comprised of familiarising with the data, generating codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining themes, and producing the findings report.

Table 2. Participant profile

Participant	Pseudonym	Age Range	SM use (h/d)	SM types for hotel information search
1	George	26-29	10-12	TripAdvisor, Facebook, Instagram, Twitter
2	Erika	22-25	5-6	TripAdvisor, Facebook, Instagram
3	Dean	22-25	3-4	Facebook, TripAdvisor
4	Mohamed	30-33	3-4	TripAdvisor
5	Marie	22-25	3-4	Instagram, Facebook, TripAdvisor, YouTube
6	Arianna	22-25	1-2	TripAdvisor, Facebook, Instagram, Twitter
7	Rosa	22-25	1-2	TripAdvisor, Facebook, Instagram
8	Moritz	26-29	3-4	TripAdvisor, Facebook
9	Anna	18-21	5-6	Facebook, TripAdvisor, Twitter, Instagram
10	Andrei	26-29	3-4	TripAdvisor, Facebook, YouTube
11	Stella	18-21	1-2	TripAdvisor
12	Nichol	26-29	5-6	Facebook, YouTube, TripAdvisor, Instagram

4. Results: Hotel Consumer Decision-Journey through Social Media

The thematic analysis reveals several themes that explain the influence of social media on the consumers' hotel DMP. In order to elicit nuances of the Evaluation stage, consumers' information search behaviour labelled 'then and now', the advantages, disadvantages, and the trustworthiness of social media and their influence on the consumers' hotel decision are presented. These findings are then integrated into a 'Hotel consumer decision-journey through social media' model, which contributes to the traditional CDJ framework and adds several layers to the Evaluation stage. The final section contextualises the hotel CDJ by providing three consumer scenarios, which

reveal common narratives and shall demonstrate how social media influence in the hotel CDJ process unfolds in practice.

4.2. Hotel Information Search: Then and Now

In order to determine the influence of social media on the hotel information search behaviour, participants frequently drew a comparison between their hotel search ‘then’ (hotel selection pre social media) and ‘now’ (hotel selection after social media). Participants highlighted that in the pre-social media era, they mostly used to seek information and advice from ‘official sources’, such as travel agencies, called various hotels to get details or made hotel reservations over the phone. Based on their answers pertaining to ‘then’, other key information sources were personal WOM that included suggestions from friends and family, official travel books and travel guides, as well as the use of traditional Web 1.0 platforms, such as hotel websites, which were used then and still continue to represent an important source for hotel information search now. When it comes to social media use, consumers use various Web 2.0 channels to conduct a comprehensive hotel search, with TripAdvisor being the most significant channel, followed by Facebook, and Instagram, YouTube and Twitter being mentioned in a few instances. This seems to be in line with previous work (McCarthy et al., 2010; Ayeh et al., 2012) noting the use of ‘different social platforms for different specific purposes’. The study also found Instagram to play a role in the hotel decision journey, as consumers access pictures, videos and hashtags relating to prospective travel, which may be an indication for this channel to play a bigger role within a sample of the younger generation of consumers. In the CDJ, it appears that ‘sources of information’ associated with now and then, are not mutually exclusive, but instead, participants seem to mix and ‘switch’ between classic websites and social media on a continuous basis. In this respect, social media constitute the primary channel for information search, while this may be complemented with search engines, visits to the hotel official webpages and use of booking sites such as Booking.com to find information and make decisions before booking a hotel, and vice versa.

“I write on Google the name of the hotel, to find the official hotel website. Then I search on social media like Facebook, Twitter and Instagram about what people write.”
(George)

“I am checking on Booking.com the prices and make a shortlist of hotels. Then I compare them on TripAdvisor.” (Mohamed)

The underlying reasons for social media use predominantly related to their ability to offer the necessary information on a wide range of hotels and answering individual questions through a combination of reviews, comments, ratings, pictures and videos, strengthening their decision process. The combination of diverse channels allows consumers a) to get access to UGC from fellow travellers who have already visited certain hotels, b) to compare hotels with one another and c) to gather an ‘*objective and authentic overview*’ of the offers available. While websites are still used for hotel search, social media offer distinct value by allowing to search ‘for very specific factors’ that might be difficult to obtain via ‘traditional information routes’, such as information about the cleanliness, location, price, and the proximity of the hotel to central places. The overall consensus is that consumers want to create a ‘bigger picture’ that draws together basic hotel information, as well as specific authentic insights which allow them to make more informed decisions based on previous visitors’ experiences.

“It is really important for me to see the travellers’ photos firstly and then look at the guests’ reviews.” (Mohamed)

“Mostly I am searching about cleanliness. Moreover I look for the location. Price is not so important for me, as I prefer quality.” (Erika)

While Baruka and Civre (2012) argued that accommodation purchases were predominantly reinforced by brochures and contacts with a travel agent, the interviews suggest combined use of Web 1.0 and social media sources with an iterative ‘switching’ taking place as the information is gathered and verified towards a final hotel decision.

4.3. Advantages and Disadvantages of Hotel Information Search through Social Media

A second theme highlighted that consumers, although technology-savvy, seem to not unconditionally use social media, but evaluate a set of distinct benefits and challenges within the hotel selection process. Participants value social media as highly beneficial information sources to access updated information on hotels, compared to less dynamic

and outdated information and content available on more traditional travel channels. An additional benefit is the possibility of ‘being able to expose oneself’ to various opinions and real life experiences from users all around the world in the pre-decision-making stage. Participants argued the value of social media in offering an easy, convenient and quick way to obtain necessary hotel information, with TripAdvisor as a key platform to compare and contrast alternatives, resulting in the ideal hotel choice.

“They are updated. You can read a comment from people that went there even the previous day.” (Rosa)

“I find out other people’s point of view and experiences there.” (Dean)

Participants further mentioned that value of UGC, which provides them with a wider background of a hotel, through pictures, videos, comments and reviews, leading to a distinct insight into the ‘true nature’ of a hotel. Social media were further praised as helpful tools as an ‘objective source of content’, that gives ‘real’ and ‘equal insights to both positive and negative’ characteristics and customer experiences.

“Social media can make you virtualise the place. You can see the rooms and you can see yourself wondering around the hotel.” (Anna)

While all participants indicated a widespread social media use in the hotel evaluation process, some participants expressed concerns relating to the trustworthiness of the content. Participants are concerned that some content might be ‘fake’, which occasionally makes social media a ‘doubtful tool’ to consult for important decision-making processes, such as holiday purchases. While the access to the wide pool of hotel-related information was perceived as positive, the same information was deemed as potentially ‘confusing’ and in fact, ‘complicating the hotel selection process’. This is due to the countless options of hotels available and their often contradicting evaluation on social media, which renders the hotel selection in many instances a ‘more time-consuming’ activity than ever before.

“There is a lot of content that is not so necessary for me.” (Erika)

“Sometimes it is confusing to have so many options. It can more time-consuming.”

(Rosa)

The findings are consistent with recent studies (Sigala et al. 2012; Zeng 2013), suggesting that social media help users accumulate information about products and services, evaluate alternatives, save time, make their decisions easily and select the most appropriate accommodation. The findings point to the fact that social media manifest several challenges, which may limit the usefulness of social media at times. There however was a consensus among participants, that while negative aspects exist, the positive benefits outweigh the negative aspects of using social media when it comes to hotel selection. Some participants stated that they would *‘always choose social media’* for their hotel information search, without going back to traditional information sources.

4.4. Trustworthiness of Social Media

Trustworthiness is an important issue during the hotel DMP (Lopez and Sicilia 2014) and emerged through three dimensions in this study: a) social media trustworthiness compared to traditional media, b) social media trustworthiness issues and c) the relationship between the source of content and trustworthiness. The majority of the participants generally trust social media content when selecting hotels, considering them a ‘non-biased’ and ‘honest’ information source. Participants emphasised that they are more likely influenced by and trust content from social media than equal content from ‘traditional’ and ‘official’ (e.g. websites, newspapers, magazines) information sources, which potentially is ‘less objective and biased’, commercially driven or financially bestowed. Trustworthiness is an important factor in participants’ hotel information search and in the conclusion leading to their final hotel decision. However, the fact that *‘anybody can post anything they want on social media’* was a concern shared by many participants, questioning the trustworthiness of the content. Participants confirmed that this may create problems at times, when there is a suspicion that content might be fake, created by companies themselves to ‘improve reality’ or created by competitors who want to defame other businesses.

“Social media is based on non-biased strangers, there is no agenda, is honest and open, so I definitely trust them.” (Mohamed)

“Companies can manipulate the information available on websites. It is not so objective. I prefer to have a third party and listen to the experiences of them.” (Arianna)

“Many comments can be fake or they are written from competitors in order to destroy the reputation of other hotels, so they are not trustworthy.” (George)

Participants also highlighted the theme ‘variations of trust levels’ pertaining to the source of the content. The highest level of trust was through social media via a personal contacts level. Participants seem to mostly trust and be influenced by social media content shared by their own ‘personal circle’, including the friends and family domain. They find it more helpful and credible, because it derives from users who they know personally, further influencing their decision. The second most trustworthy content level is the one originating from ‘other users’. UGC content by strangers gives a variety of opinions and offers content that is potentially trustworthy, while company UGC on social media was perceived as least reliable, possibly concealing negative sides.

“I tend to trust my own friends more because I know them personally. After my friends I trust other users on social media and then the companies.” (Erika)

4.5. Influence of Social Media on Consumers’ Hotel Decision-Making Process

The final theme relates to the deeper nuances of social media use that influence the consumers’ hotel DMP. Participants generally agreed that social media content plays an important role when deciding which hotel to pick. Thereby, participants distinguish three main ‘levels of content’, which influence them in their decision-making, including a) positive content on social media, b) negative content on social media and c) lack and inexistence of content.

On a ‘positive content level’ participants noted that positive comments, reviews, high ratings and attractive pictures influence them positively on 'initiating and getting them triggered to consider and select hotels in the final evaluation stage. Several participants start a hotel search and positive content influences them to ‘shortlist’ a hotel. For instance, a Facebook post by strangers or friends with positive comments about a hotel

would influence participants favourably, inspiring them to find ‘more information’ and possibly ‘paying a visit’. Positive content is however not always an ‘absolute factor’ leading to a hotel decision. Hotels with positive content are only considered, if they are ‘convenient’, for example, if they are a) in the destination they are planning to go and if b) the hotel is ‘affordable’. This indicates that positive social media content seems to be supportive, but not decisive and able to change the mind of consumers, as hotel decisions appear to be contextually co-shaped by consumers’ prior defined location and price expectations.

Negative social media content does not necessarily exclude hotels, but makes prospective travellers rather ‘hesitant’ in choosing a particular hotel. The majority of participants said that they personally believe that negative content has a more powerful effect on them than positive content. While a hotel with positive content might be considered an option, a hotel with negative content is much more likely to be ‘excluded’ from the list of possible choices. Participants reported that negative content is critical to make a ‘concrete decision fairly easily’, i.e., rejecting a hotel in favour of another hotel. In terms of type of content, it appears that negative reviews and comments, low ratings and poor pictures, which portray a hotel’s weaknesses seem to affect participants most. A minority of participants reported to have cancelled a reservation after having come across negative content in the past, causing them to restart their information search and decision-making cycle. In particular, if ‘negative comments outnumber positive ones’, a hotel would definitely not be booked. The following quotes underline how easily consumers are swayed to ‘reject’ a hotel based on a negative content associated.

“Some people post pictures where the hotel looks worse than the hotel website’s pictures. When I see that, I change my mind.” (Moritz)

“Once, I had booked a hotel and after reading the reviews I found out that it was really bad. So, I cancelled the hotel and then I booked another one.” (Mohamed)

Several participants explained that they would not automatically ‘disregard hotels with negative reviews’. Instead, the way they are being influenced is rather dependent on ‘which kind of the negative content’ is presented. For instance, participants explained that negative comments about an instance that is not personally relevant or important, a

hotel would still be considered for booking. In contrast, if the negative review is personally significant (e.g. cleanliness, customer service, Wi-Fi), participants would refrain from booking a hotel and mentally put it on the ‘do not book list’.

Third, the findings indicate that a ‘lack or non-existence of content’ on social media plays a critical role in shaping consumers’ hotel selection process. Participants explained that if a hotel does not have a ‘respectable amount of UGC’, based on which a comprehensive evaluation can be made, they would not consider it. Instead, they prefer finding a hotel with more content that gives them the ‘confidence to verify’ that the right decision is being made. In fact, if there is no ‘critical mass of reviews’, participants argued that it would lead them to feel as though ‘something is wrong’ or even ‘suspicious’ with the hotel, in case it is not possible to find available pictures, comments or reviews of a hotel online.

By pointing to three distinct ‘content levels’, the analysis points to underlying drivers that influence a hotel DMP. These insights suggest that the influence of social media on the hotel DMP cannot be simplified. It would be too simplistic to say that positive content leads to selection, while negative content leads to the rejection of a hotel. Instead, the findings show the importance of recognising a contextual influence of social media on hotel selection, based not only on the a) the source of content, b) the trustworthiness and c) the level of content, i.e. positive, negative, inexistent content, summarised in Figure 1 below.

4.6. The Hotel Consumer Decision-Journey through Social Media

The themes emerged through the qualitative in-depth interviews contributed to the development of an integrated “*Hotel consumer decision-journey through social media*” model. Within the wider CDJ, this study draws particular focus on understanding of the ‘*Evaluation stage*’, in which the hotel information search and selection through social media occurs. The thematic analysis reveals advantages and disadvantages of social media, levels of trustworthiness, a comparison of Web 1.0 and Web 2.0 sources and three distinct levels of content and their respective influence on the way consumers search, evaluate and choose a hotel.

Figure 1. The hotel consumer decision-journey through social media

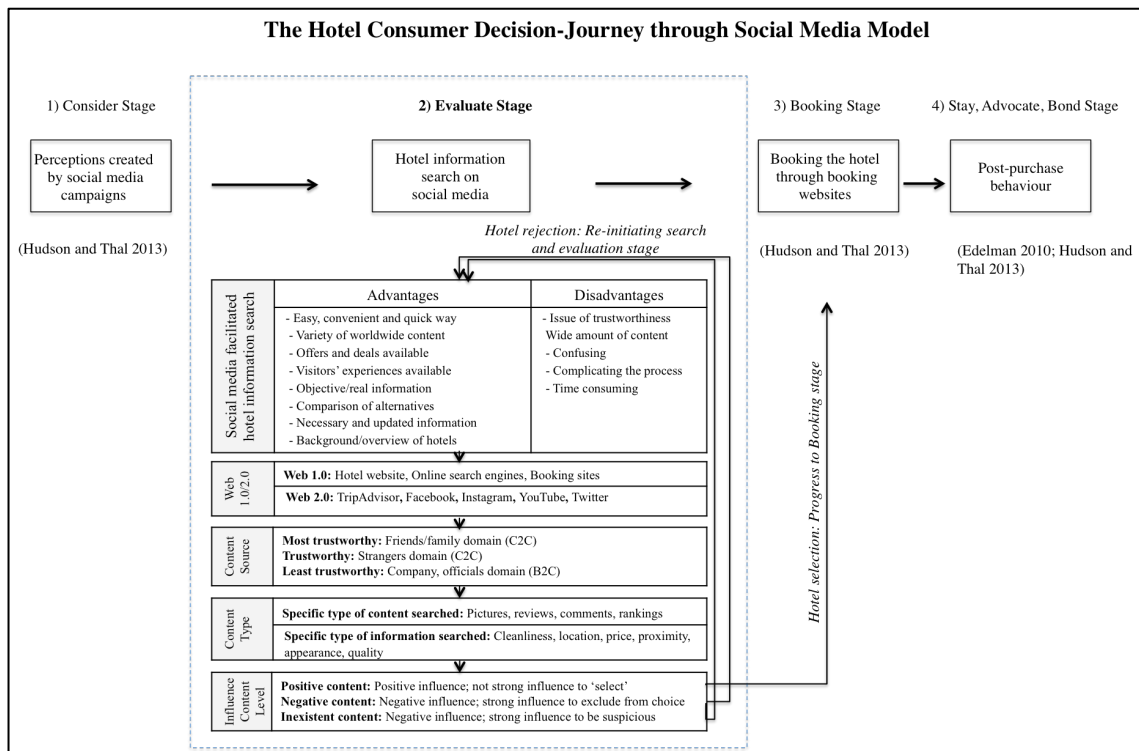
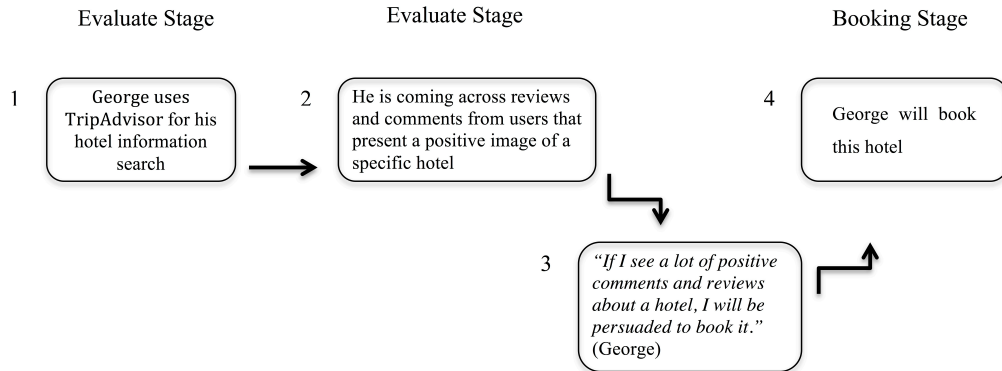


Figure 1 expand the Evaluate stage by capturing a variety of social media induced processes taking place. It distinguishes underlying reasons for social media use, related to advantages and disadvantages, a switching process between Web 1.0 and 2.0 sources, trustworthiness levels relating to the source of content, the content type, as well as demonstrating the influence of diverse content levels on the final decision making. Based on this set of information, influencing hotel selection process, the evaluation stage is concluded with the consumer's final decision, deciding to proceed with a particular hotel choice towards the Booking Stage (feedback loop – next stage), or reject a particular hotel choice and re-initiate the information and evaluation stage (feedback loop – repetition of stage).

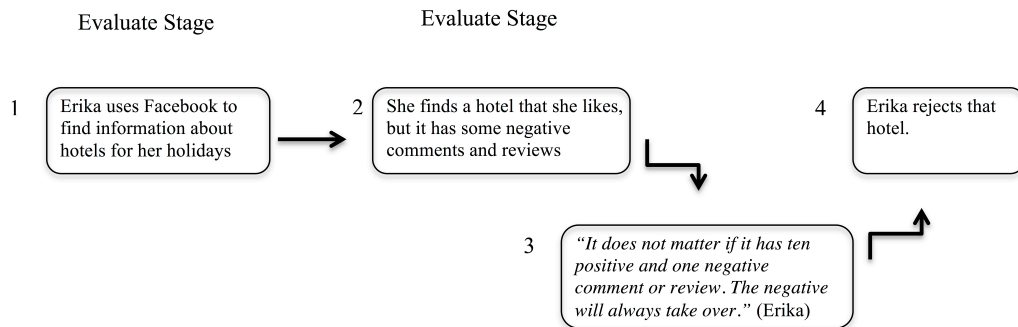
4.7. Hotel Decision-Making Scenarios

By building upon this model and offer relevant implications for practice, three 'hotel decision-making scenarios' are offered, providing an insight into participant narratives showcasing how the hotel decision-making might unfold with social media in place.

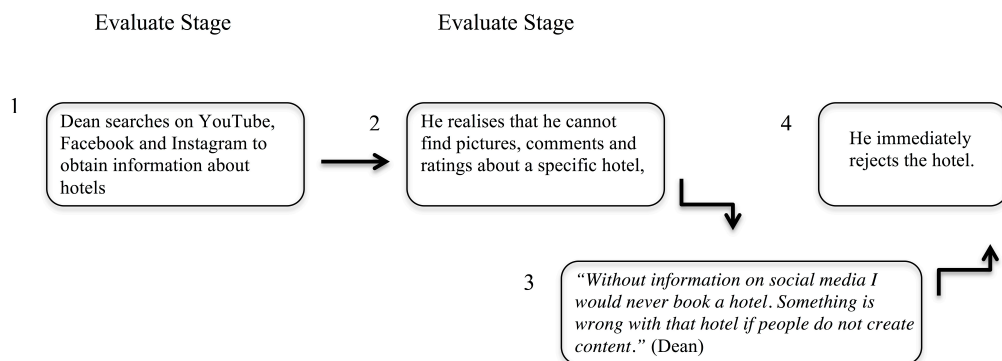
Scenario 1. Influence from positive content



Scenario 2. Influence from negative content



Scenario 3. Influence from inexistent content



5. Conclusions, Limitations and Implications

Consumers use a range of social media to share travel-related experiences, engage with others, connect with people from different destinations and purchase travel-related products and services online (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010; Zeng and Geritsen 2014). Potential tourists are influenced in their decision-making by social media, as content and opinions from other travellers can shape, guide and redirect initial and final decisions (Fotis et al. 2012). This study has examined the customer decision journey in a hospitality context and shed light on the nuances of how social media influence the evaluation stage when choosing a hotel. Several theoretical and practical implications unfold. The study makes a theoretical contribution in that it bridges consumer behaviour and social media literature in the hotel context and contributes to a more refined understanding of the hotel consumer decision journey through social media. This paper contributes by revealing the influence of social media on a number of levels, which were graphically summarised in a model that depicts the hotel consumer decision journey and outlined in a set of real-life scenarios of social media influence on the CDJ for management and practice.

For the travel and hospitality industry, a number of implications emerge from this study for the awareness, understanding and management of the role and influence of social media on the hotel CDJ. First, this study has shown that a wide variety of social media with associated content sources and levels add to the wider influence of how consumers engage in hotel-related information search and decision. The findings not only help hotel professionals to understand consumers' different levels (e.g. type of content, content source, content level) on which social media might inform the hotel DMP. The theoretical model and real-life scenarios shall help practitioners to better understand the fine nuances and complexities of how consumers are influenced by social media and how this causes them to iteratively change their minds and make final decisions in the rejection or selection of a hotel. Hotels thus should be aware of the importance of the content represented on social media to make sure that their actions lead to the generation of positive content through close social circles to the consumer, while minimising negative and addressing inexistent content by facilitating the generation of comprehensive content that helps consumers in making an informed decision towards their hotel choice.

As with any empirical research, several limitations are acknowledged. The study's scope to generate qualitative in-depth insights into the 'Evaluate Stage' of the wider hotel CDJ asked for a compromise on a random sample and in turn the transferability of the findings beyond hotel and tourism consumer decision-making contexts. In offering an expanded hotel CDJ model, this work hopes to stimulate further research that expands on various content levels and examines tourism-related CDJ processes as decision making increasingly unfolds on-site, as customers make dynamic decisions with help of social and mobile platforms on the go. In considering the social media domain as a fast evolving one, research could focus on video and live-streaming networking sites (e.g. Instagram Boomerang, Periscope, Vine) to understand their influence and effect on hotel and travel related decision-making.

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